Sripada Madhvacharya

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The Acharya of Tattvavada

Madhvacharya lived more than two centuries before Sri Chaitanya, and yet his name is inseparable from the Gaudiya sampradaya. As a child he was called Vasudeva; on taking sannyasa he became Purnaprajna Tirtha, and from his guru he also received the title Anandatirtha — the name under which he most often appears in the scriptures. Srila Jiva Gosvami calls him “our former acharya, the eldest Vaishnava Anandatirtha.”

Madhva's teaching is called dvaita-vada, the doctrine of difference (bheda-vada), or “pure dvaita” (shuddha-dvaita), and his followers are known as Tattvavadis. The line he founded — the Madhva sampradaya, also called the Brahma sampradaya — is one of the four Vaishnava sampradayas of our age, together with the Sri, Rudra and Sanaka sampradayas. The Gaudiya Vaishnavas, too, descend in the line of Brahma: they call their succession the “Brahma-Madhva-Gaudiya-Sarasvata sampradaya,” or simply “Madhva-Gaudiya.”

Birth and Childhood

According to inscriptions at Sri Kurma (Srikurmam) left by his direct disciple Narahari Tirtha, Madhva was born in 1238 and lived seventy-nine years, until 1317; the “Anu-Madhva-charita” confirms these dates. The biographies his disciples composed soon after his departure name as his birthplace a settlement eight miles southeast of Udupi, in present-day Karnataka.[1] In our calendar the day of his appearance is Gaura-dashami of the month of Padmanabha, the festival of Vijaya-dashami.[2] According to Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati, the temple of Sri Kurma later came under the rule of the Vijayanagara kings and into the care of the Sri Madhva Math.

His father's name was Madhyageha Bhatta; the family belonged to the Avalli brahmanas. The clan traced itself back to Parashurama, the brahmana-warrior and incarnation of God, and this, it is said, is why Madhva was tall, strong and sturdy of body.

Wondrous tales of his childhood have come down, which one biography relates in the words of Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami. When his father fell into debt, the boy turned tamarind seeds into coins to pay it off. At five he was invested with the sacred thread — and at that same age, with one toe of the left foot, he slew the demon Maniman, who lived nearby in the form of a serpent. Whenever his mother grew anxious for him, he would reach her side in a single leap. His learning, too, showed itself from his earliest years.

Sannyasa

At twelve, against his father's wishes, he left home to accept sannyasa from Achyutapreksha.[3] In his ashrama he studied the commentaries of various acharyas on the Vedanta, beginning with the “Ishta-siddhi” of Vimuktatman. The deeper he went into the scriptures, the more clearly he saw the weakness of the Advaitic interpretation, and he resolved to restore the original meaning of the Vedanta, which affirms God as a Person. Soon he began to defeat Achyutapreksha himself in debate, and his teacher, acknowledging his superiority, made him head of the ashrama and bestowed on him the name Anandatirtha.

As head of the ashrama Madhva began to teach, and he prevailed over scholars of every school — Buddhists, Jains, Advaitins and other impersonalists, agnostics, logicians, adherents of ritual religion.

His system had already taken complete shape, but was not yet written down.

Journey through the South

From Udupi he set out south as far as Kanyakumari, then on to Rameshvaram, Srirangam and other holy places, everywhere defeating the scholars of Shankara's school. It is said that at Kanyakumari one of them told him, “Since you disagree with your teacher, write your own commentary on the Vedanta,” and Madhva gave his word. At Srirangam he came to know Ramanuja's vishishtadvaita, but it did not satisfy him: in his view it refuted Shankara's speculation too weakly. So his resolve to compose a commentary of his own grew firm.

With Vyasa at Badari

Before undertaking the work he wished to receive the blessing of Vedavyasa, who, it was said, is deathless and lives in his ashrama at Badari, unseen by mortals. Madhva walked to the Ananta Math at Badrinatha and spent seven weeks there in fasting, prayer and meditation. Then, following an inner prompting, he climbed higher, to Badarikashrama (Upper Badari), the abode of Vyasadeva. There he met Vyasa and set before him his commentary on the “Bhagavad-gita”; Vyasa approved it and gave him the shalagrama-shila “Ashtamurti.”

His conversations with Vyasa deepened still further his understanding of the scriptures. He stayed several months at Badarikashrama until he had completed the commentary on the “Gita,” and on returning to the Ananta Math he dictated it to his companion Satya Tirtha. During that period he composed his Brahma-sutra commentary as well.

The Return

The way back led through Bihar and Bengal, Orissa and Andhra, and everywhere Madhva defeated scholars of various schools in debate. According to the “Madhva-vijaya,” at Ganjam on the Godavari he met two outstanding scholars, Shobhana Bhatta and Svami Shastri. Both accepted his teaching and became Padmanabha Tirtha and Narahari Tirtha — the school's chief acharyas next to Madhva himself. Narahari Tirtha wrote commentaries on Madhva's “Gita-bhashya” and “Karma-nirnaya” and from 1271 to 1293 was the first minister of Kalinga; Padmanabha Tirtha was the first to comment on many of his master's principal works — the “Brahma-sutra-bhashya,” the “Anuvyakhyana,” the “Dasha-prakaranas.”

Through Andhra, Maharashtra and Karnataka Madhva returned to Udupi. There he turned his former guru Achyutapreksha from Shankara's Vedanta to Vaishnavism and received him among his followers: the guru became the disciple. Madhva's fame grew, his commentaries on the “Gita” and the Vedanta won recognition, and followers flocked to him from all over India.

Krishna at Udupi

At Udupi Madhva bathed in the sea every day. One day, as he sat on the shore meditating on Krishna, he saw that a ship making for Dvaraka was about to run aground, and with signals he guided it safely to shore. The captain wished to reward him, and Madhva accepted from him nothing but a large block of gopi-chandana. As it was being handed over, it split open, and inside was a large Deity of Krishna. Madhva took Him as a gift of the Lord's grace and composed beautiful prayers to Sri Krishna. The Deity was so heavy that thirty men could scarcely have moved Him, but Madhva, who possessed superhuman strength, carried Him to Udupi himself. Soon Krishna was installed in a temple, where He resides to this day.

Having installed the Deity, Madhva reformed the order of worship and gave his followers strict rules of ritual and conduct, including a strict fast on Ekadashi.

Two centuries later Sri Chaitanya came to Udupi. The “Charitamrita” relates:

“Then He came to Udupi, the chief residence of the Tattvavadis, the followers of Madhvacharya. Seeing the Deity of Krishna there, He became mad with the overflowing emotions of divine love. There too He saw the wondrously beautiful Deity of Dancing Gopala, who had appeared to Madhvacharya in a dream. One day Madhvacharya found this Deity in a heap of gopi-chandana being carried on a boat. Madhvacharya brought the Deity to Udupi and duly installed Him in the temple, where his followers worship Him to this day. Sri Chaitanya was inexpressibly glad to see this Deity of Krishna. In the bliss of prema He sang and danced a great deal.” (CC, Madhya 9.245–249)

At first the Tattvavadis took Mahaprabhu for a Mayavadi sannyasi and kept away from Him; but when they saw how deeply He was immersed in the bliss of prema, they realised that a Vaishnava stood before them and welcomed Him with deep respect. Noticing that they took pride in their Vaishnavism, the Lord smiled and humbly asked their acharya, a master of all the scriptures, what the real goal of human life is and by what means it is attained. The acharya replied that one should live by the rules of varnashrama and dedicate everything to Krishna — this is the way to Krishna-bhakti — and that the highest goal is the five kinds of liberation and passage to Vaikuntha. The Lord answered that the scriptures call hearing about Krishna and glorifying Him the highest practice, whose fruit is prema, the fifth and highest goal of life; the scriptures reject work for its fruits, and Krishna's devotees will not accept even the five kinds of liberation, valuing them no more than hell. Abashed, the acharya conceded that He was right, but said, “Yet we fully follow the practice that Madhvacharya laid down for our whole community.” Then Sri Chaitanya said:

“Neither in selfish pious work nor in the striving for liberation is there devotion to God. And in your community I see the marks of both these aims. Of all possible virtues I see only one in your community: you accept the eternal form of the Lord, as the holy Deity, to be real.” (CC, Madhya 9.276–277)

Thus the Lord broke the pride of the Tattvavadis, who held their practice to be the model of Vaishnavism. His reproach concerned the practice of the Tattvavadi community of His day, while the one virtue He acknowledged in it — the eternal form of God — lies at the very root of Madhva's teaching; as will be seen below, this is precisely why Mahaprabhu accepted his sampradaya. In its brief summary of the pastimes the “Charitamrita” says that after discussing the Truth with Him the Tattvavadis owned themselves inferior to Him (Madhya 1.114), and at the start of the account of the South it remarks that only a few of the Vaishnavas there followed Madhvacharya or Ramanujacharya (Madhya 9.11).

The Second Pilgrimage to the North

Later Madhva went north again, to Badarikashrama. The “Madhva-vijaya,” composed by the son of a disciple of Madhva, says that in his preaching he was helped by his wit, his fearlessness and his command of many tongues, Turkic and Persian among them.

In those parts by the Ganga, enmity between Hindus and Muslims was such that no one dared to cross the river, and there were no boats. Madhva and his disciples swam across, heedless of the Muslim guards, and the whole party was seized. Brought before Sultan Jalal ad-Din Khilji, Madhva spoke with him at length in Persian about devotion to God. The sultan softened and offered him lands and money, but Madhva humbly declined — and the biographer cites this refusal as an example of true renunciation.

Tradition tells that once he saved his disciple, the sannyasi Satya Tirtha, from a Bengal tiger, beating the beast off with his bare hands, and that another time he easily fought off robbers. He lived a long life in

good health, and practised wrestling, swimming and mountain climbing. According to the “Madhva-vijaya,” the strongman Kadanjari, who was as strong as thirty men, could not move even his big toe. Trivikrama Pandita writes that Madhva bore all thirty-two marks of a great personality, had a deep, melodious voice and was a skilled singer; his reading of “Bhagavatam” verses was renowned for its sweetness.

Madhva visited Badrinatha, Delhi, Kurukshetra, Benares and Goa, and afterwards travelled mostly in the south, around Udupi. After Shankaracharya he was the second great acharya of the Vedanta to tour the whole of India. Disciples came to him from many lands, and today his followers speak eight languages — Tulu, Kannada, Konkani, Marathi, Telugu, southern Saurashtri, Bengali and Hindi.

Writings

Madhva left commentaries on the “Gita” and the Brahma-sutras (the “Purnaprajna-bhashya”) and on the ten principal Upanishads; ten treatises, the “Dasha-prakaranas”; the “Anuvyakhyana,” which many regard as his chief work; a digest of the “Mahabharata”; and a commentary on the “Srimad-Bhagavatam,” the “Bhagavata-tatparya.” In his last years he wrote the “Nyaya-vivarana,” the “Karma-nirnaya,” the “Krishnamrita-maharnava” and other books, and his final work was a commentary on the “Aitareya Upanishad.”

In his bhashya Madhva cites verses of the “Brahma-tarka” on the eternal non-difference of the whole and its parts, of the energy and its Possessor, in Janardana. Srila Jiva Gosvami accepted these verses as authoritative, though he had never seen the “Brahma-tarka” itself.

Opponents and Disciples

Madhva's learning and devotion to the Lord made him hateful to the followers of Shankara, the acharyas of the Sringeri Math, who held themselves to be the only legitimate Vedantists; the biographer plainly calls their conduct tyranny. They persecuted Madhva's disciples, tried to prove that he had no legitimate succession, and challenged him to debate. Their champion, the scholar Pundarika Puri, was defeated, and then his accomplice, the sannyasi Padma Tirtha, in revenge stole a collection of ancient Sanskrit manuscripts from Madhva's library. The books were retrieved through Jayasimha, the raja of Kumbla.

After meeting the raja, Madhva entered into debate with his court pandita, Trivikrama Pandita of Vishnumangala — the foremost authority on Advaita Vedanta in Kumbla, and a poet. The debate lasted fifteen days in the Kidil temple, and in the end Trivikrama acknowledged Madhva as his guru and became his disciple; at his bidding he composed a Vedanta commentary, the “Tattva-pradipa.”

This conversion changed the course of Madhva's mission. Trivikrama's brother and seven other scholars took sannyasa from Madhva, becoming the first heads of the eight Madhva mathas at Udupi. Trivikrama's son, Narayana Panditacharya, wrote the “Madhva-vijaya” — the life which Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami recommends to anyone wishing to know more of Madhva. Sannyasa from him was also received by the learned preachers Padmanabha Tirtha, Narahari Tirtha, Madhava Tirtha and Akshobhya Tirtha, who carried on his work.

Departure

By the close of his days Madhva had accomplished all he had set out to do: his teaching had been preached, his system worked out, preachers trained, and his books went on to shape theistic thought in India right up to the twentieth century. In 1317, just short of his eightieth year, having completed a commentary on the “Aitareya Upanishad,” he departed for the eternal Vaikuntha. It was the ninth lunar day of Magha's bright half (January–February) — in our calendar, Gaura-navami of the month of Madhava.

Teaching

Baladeva Vidyabhushana in the “Prameya-ratnavali” sums up in nine principles whatever in Madhva's teaching runs level with that of Sri Chaitanya (one biography describes the book as a statement of the principles the two schools share); the verse “śrī-madhvaḥ prāha viṣṇuṁ paratamam…” lists them thus: Hari, Krishna, is the Supreme Truth; the Vedas reveal Him; the world has reality; the jivas are distinct from the Lord; by nature they are servants of Hari; the jivas differ in their positions — some are liberated, some conditioned; liberation is attainment of the feet of Vishnu, eternal service to Him; the way to it is pure bhakti; the sources of true knowledge are perception, inference and the word of scripture. These same principles Sri Krishna Chaitanya also taught.[4]

Srila Jiva Gosvami says in the “Sarva-samvadini” that Ramanuja and Madhva hold the doctrine of difference, whereas ours is achintya-bheda-abheda, inconceivable oneness and difference. Examining four kinds of teaching on bhakti, he notes that for Madhva the jiva is distinct from Ishvara, yet devotion to Ishvara is its very nature. One of the biographies, telling of Baladeva Vidyabhushana, explains that the shruti contains texts on both oneness and difference; Shankara relied on the one set, Madhva on those that support dvaita, and so neither absolute advaita nor dvaita, taken alone, agrees with the shruti as a whole — whereas Baladeva reconciled them. The same account adds that Madhva did speak of achintya-bheda-abheda but laid no stress on it, holding fast to “pure dvaita,” while the Gaudiyas joined the teaching of difference to that of non-difference in a way of their own.

Together with Ramanuja, Vishnusvami, Nimbarka and Sri Chaitanya, Madhva fought Shankara's mayavada, the doctrine of appearance (vivarta-vada); those who seek true good follow Vyasa's teaching that it is the Lord's energy which transforms (shakti-parinama-vada). Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati said that only fools consider it a hindrance to devotion to teach through books, as Rupa, Sanatana, Jiva and Raghunatha Dasa did, or to have many disciples, as Madhva, Ramanuja and Narottama did.

Madhva and the Gaudiya Sampradaya

In the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” (21–24) Kavi Karnapura says that in the age of Kali four sampradayas appeared — of Sri, Brahma, Rudra and Sanaka — and describes one of them, the sampradaya of Madhva, in detail. The disciple of the Lord of Paravyoma was Brahma; his disciple, Narada; Narada's disciple, Vyasa; and Shuka became Vyasa's disciple. “From Vyasa the renowned Madhvacharya received initiation into the Krishna mantra. Having analysed the Vedas, he composed the compendium ‘Shatadushani,’ in which Brahman with qualities is upheld as against Brahman without qualities” (GGD 22). After him come Padmanabhacharya, Narahari, the brahmana Madhava, Akshobhya, Jayatirtha, Jnanasindhu, Mahanidhi, Vidyanidhi, Rajendra, Jayadharma (from whose circle came Vishnupuri, author of the “Bhakti-ratnavali”), Purushottama, Brahmanya, Vyasatirtha, Lakshmipati and Madhavendra Puri; from him, Ishvara Puri; and from Ishvara Puri, Sri Chaitanya. Madhva is thus fourth from Brahma, and Madhavendra Puri fifteenth after Madhva. The same line is given in the “Prameya-ratnavali” and by Gopala Guru Gosvami.

The “Bhakti-ratnakara” (5) tells that in Brahma's line Sri Madhva first of all composed a bhashya on the Brahma-sutras and, since he gave it his own name, came himself to be called Madhvacharya — hence the Madhvacharya sampradaya; his other name is Sri Anandatirtha, “known everywhere, matchless in every virtue,” and his countless disciples and their disciples spread bhakti far and wide. The Lord, the book says, glorified this sampradaya in the age of Kali. There the line is numbered from Brahma to Gaurachandra Himself, who stands twentieth, and Madhva again is fourth; the verses of the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” and of Gopala Guru follow.[5]

Baladeva Vidyabhushana, in five verses of the “Prameya-ratnavali,” derives the Gaudiya sampradaya from Madhva and lists the acharyas from him to Sri Chaitanya, beginning with his direct disciples Padmanabha and Narahari; the list was evidently taken from the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika,” as well as from Gopala Guru's “Sadhana-paddhati” and the writings of Dhyanachandra, Chaitanya Dasa and Manohara Dasa. The Madhva acharya Vyasatirtha stands in this line, according to one biography, fourteen generations after Madhva; a Vallabhite tradition even tells that, as head of the “great seat” of the Madhva sampradaya, he offered that seat to Vallabha.

A verse of the “Padma Purana,” quoted in both the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” and the “Bhakti-ratnakara,” says: “Mantras received outside a sampradaya are fruitless”; in the age of Kali the earth is purified by the Vaishnavas of four sampradayas — of Sri, Brahma, Rudra and Sanaka. Their first acharyas — Ramanuja, Madhva, Vishnusvami and Nimbarka — took as their original gurus Lakshmi, Brahma, Rudra and the Sanat-kumaras respectively.

Madhavendra Puri accepted the sampradaya of Sri Madhvacharya and Vaishnava sannyasa. Mahaprabhu accepted Madhva's sampradaya because the eternal form of God, full of being, knowledge and bliss, which Madhva upheld, is the root of achintya-bheda-abheda. Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura and Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati explain that in Madhva's line, from Madhva himself down to Lakshmipati, devotion in the conjugal mood (shringara-rasa) and evidence of prema-bhakti had not been manifest — the spirit of that line can be seen from Mahaprabhu's conversation with the Tattvavadis at Udupi. Madhavendra Puri became the first shoot of divine love's wish-tree to rise from it. Something was lacking in what the earlier acharyas concluded, and Sri Chaitanya completed them — Madhva's teaching of the eternal form of God among them — by revealing the perfect doctrine of achintya-bheda-abheda.

Srila Jiva Gosvami in the “Tattva-sandarbha” (4–5) names Madhvacharya among the ancient Vaishnavas who wrote of Bhagavan, and says that he consulted Madhva, Shridhara Svami and Ramanuja. He knew that the foundation of achintya-bheda-abheda lies in Madhva's “Bhagavata-tatparya,” and says himself that he followed the “Tatparya”; in the supplementary commentary on the “Tattva-sandarbha” he examines the teachings of Madhvacharya and Ramanujacharya. Gopala Bhatta Gosvami compiled the “Sat-kriya-sara-dipika” “out of kindness to the noble ones in the sampradaya of Madhva”; a manuscript from Sanketa describing the abodes of the four sampradayas opens with obeisance to Madhvacharya as guru.

Baladeva Vidyabhushana had earlier studied the teaching of Madhva's followers in Mysore, at a Tattvavadi temple, took sannyasa in their school and preached Tattvavada until he met Radha-Damodara. Later, at Galta near Jaipur, the Ramanandis demanded that the Gaudiyas either prove their unity with Madhva by accepting his bhashya and order of worship, or show a commentary on the Vedanta of their own. Baladeva explained that neither Sri Chaitanya nor the six Gosvamis had accepted Madhva's bhashya in full as the Gaudiya teaching, yet they had written no commentary of their own on the sutras; the Gosvamis quoted Madhva just as they quoted Ramanuja, Shridhara and others. The Gaudiya philosophy is at its base Madhva's system, refined by the teaching of the “Bhagavatam,” but in many things the Gaudiyas go further, and Baladeva brought out the distinctiveness and independence of the Gaudiya system.

For Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, what matters most in an acharya is his firm grounding in the Absolute (brahma-nishtha), not merely a formal link through initiation; therefore, he taught, the Madhva-Gaudiya succession in the spirit of Sri Rupa was never broken by any “dark periods.”

Madhva and the Gaudiya Math

In 1898 Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura brought out in Bengali the “Gita” together with Madhva's commentary. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta studied the schools of Ramanuja and Madhva from books in four South Indian languages brought to him by Sundareshvar Shrauti, and collected Madhva works — the “Madhva-vijaya,” the “Purnaprajna-bhashya,” Jayatirtha's “Nyaya-sudha,” Vyasatirtha's “Nyayamrita,” a formidable weapon against mayavada, and others. He visited Udupi more than once and invited a swami from there to teach Madhva's philosophy at Mayapur. The head of the matha at Udupi and the head of the Madhva seat at Salimabad received him as a spiritual teacher of the sampradaya. He published more than two hundred books on the teaching of the Gosvamis and on the sampradayas of Sri Madhva and Sri Ramanuja, and to the Sanskrit school he founded he brought learned scholars from Udupi to teach the doctrines of the various sampradayas. In 1932, at Madras, he explained what is distinctive in the Gaudiya sampradaya to heads and scholars of the schools of Shankara, Ramanuja and Madhva, and on the road to Mysore he visited, among other places, the Madhva math at Nanjangud.

On 13 October 1921 Srila Bhaktisiddhanta founded the “Madhva-Gaudiya Math” in Dhaka, and in 1924 he spoke there at length about the life of Madhvacharya, the Madhva sampradaya and the differences between its teaching and the Gaudiya one, especially Madhva's view of varnashrama-dharma. He planned the temple of the Chaitanya Math so that at its corners would stand figures of the four sampradayas' founders — Lakshmi, Brahma, Rudra and the Kumaras — and of their acharyas: Ramanuja, Madhva, Vishnusvami and Nimbarka. Following the example of Shankara, Ramanuja, Madhva and Sri Chaitanya, he toured all of India preaching. In 1924, for Gaura-purnima, the Dhaka “Madhva-Gaudiya Math” brought out the first edition of the “Chaitanya-bhagavata,” and on 8 April 1935 he laid at Narinda Palli the foundation of a new temple building for that math.

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta held the appearance day of Madhva in special honour, and great undertakings began on it: 4 October 1919 saw the start of preaching in North and East Bengal, 9 October 1932 the start of the parikrama of Vraja-mandala over eighty-four kroshas; in 1936 it was celebrated at Chataka-parvata in Puri, together with Govardhana-puja. The song “Sri Madhva janma-tithi” is among the songs for the festivals.

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta's disciples carried on the bond with Udupi. He had wished to set Mahaprabhu's footprints at Tirupati, Srirangam and Udupi — “the chief centre of the Sri Madhva sampradaya” — but did not live to do so; Srila Bhakti Vilas Tirtha Maharaj installed them at Srirangam and Tirupati. When Udupi gave him a civic reception on 7 November 1957, the chairman of the municipality, K. K. Pai, said that the followers of Sriman Madhvacharya live throughout the land of Udupi, that the light of knowledge he kindled almost seven centuries ago shines still, and that, drawn by that light, Sri Krishna Chaitanya discussed spiritual matters with an eminent Madhva sannyasi of that day — Srila Vadiraja Tirtha of the Sode Math;[6] ever since, the swamis of the Gaudiya Math and of the eight maths of Udupi have kept in touch. Tirtha Maharaj replied that the Gaudiya Vaishnava sampradaya has its roots in the succession of the Madhva sampradaya; to it belonged Madhavendra Puri, Mahaprabhu's parama-guru and the first master-builder of a distinctive prema-bhakti, while Mahaprabhu Himself became the chief preacher of that love in the mood of vipralambha, separation. The acharyas of the four sampradayas, the Madhva among them, called Tirtha Maharaj a friend and guardian of Vaishnava philosophy.

Significance

Tradition, which one biography also records, calls Madhva an incarnation of Vayu. In a list of jagad-gurus whose position is not diminished by outward appearance, he is named “Vasudeva (Madhvacharya), who appeared as a child.” For Gaudiya Vaishnavas he is the acharya who restored to the Vedanta God as a Person, the reality of the world and the soul's eternal service to the Lord — the founder of the line through which Madhavendra Puri, Ishvara Puri and Mahaprabhu Himself came to us.

1. In the biography the settlement is called “Tulunada”; this is also the name of the whole land of the Tulu people, and the name needs to be checked against the primary sources.

2. The biography does not give the day of his appearance; the day is given according to the calendar of the Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math.

3. The “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” (22) says that Madhva received the Krishna mantra (diksha) from Vyasa; Achyutapreksha was his sannyasa-guru.

4. One of the biographies speaks of “ten points,” but lists the same nine.

5. The words “brahmaṇyaḥ puruṣottamaḥ” in GGD 22 may be read as two names (so in our translation: Purushottama and Brahmanya) or as one; the “Bhakti-ratnakara” reads a single name, “Sri Purushottama Brahmanya.” Hence by the GGD Madhavendra Puri is fifteenth after Madhva and by the “Bhakti-ratnakara” fourteenth, and Vyasatirtha thirteenth or twelfth accordingly. The “fourteenth generation” of one biography agrees with neither count.

6. The “Charitamrita” does not name the Tattvavadi acharya with whom the Lord spoke (Madhya 9.254, 9.273).